



WD My Cloud drives at risk

A security researcher has published a Password Bypass flaw in the WD My Cloud drive that puts user data at risk. <https://digit.in/oct18-29-1>



Service to monitor AI decisions

IBM launches a cloud tool that can detect AI bias and explain automated decisions for more transparency. <https://digit.in/oct18-29-2>

those changes. The last part is important to mitigate any surreptitious consent changes either the telecom provider or marketer may do without informing the user,” Kamat said.

The second question was on how the nodes and the consensus would be used. Kamat replied, “The nodes in a blockchain typically store the persistent data recorded on the chain. In this instance it likely would be a hash of the user’s consent related transactions as well as a hash of every call or SMS log from a marketer to a user. It really

against the tamper-evident ledger held by the blockchain. This makes for speedier resolutions and a much lower cost of enforcement. Two of the major problems today are that telcos typically close any user complaint with a template response saying “no fault found at our end” offering no proof of recorded consent. This is a major source of nuisance to end users that is expected to be solved by this approach. Secondly marketers or telcos surreptitiously record user consent without an explicit communication informing the

incentive to update it. Such a system has never been tested in the scale that TRAI intends to implement it. In the end, a private blockchain takes away most of the benefits of distributed ledger technologies, and is little more than a shared database.

We asked Venkat Krishnapur, Vice-President of Engineering and Managing Director - McAfee to weigh in on the security concerns. “Blockchain, being an emerging technology, is often a hotbed targeted by cybercriminals. The primary attack vectors include phishing, malware, implementation vulnerabilities, and core blockchain technology vulnerabilities. There are a number of applications and utilities that are created over the core blockchain platform – often times by ‘fly by night’ programmers or inexperienced ones who pay least attention to secure coding practices. These result in vulnerabilities in the application that can be easily exploited and once compromised, the hacker has access to a host of data and able to launch any kind of attack he so chooses.” Krishnapur said.

While it looks like TRAI is going to go ahead with the implementation of blockchain, there are some concerns that the telecom service providers themselves have raised. The telecom industry is going through a period of extreme stress, and these regulations may mean additional investments that would burden an already troubled sector. The costs include servers for maintaining multiple copies of the blockchain, high speed connections between providers, and computing resources to make sure every node stays on the server. What exacerbates the problem is that the technology is not commonly understood, and is unproven at this scale. Additionally, the operators point out that the original Do Not Disturb system did not have any major problems. Finally, the proposed regulations penalise the service providers, but not the telemarketers. An independent study by Deloitte showed that 92 per cent of the blockchain projects initiated by individuals or organisations since 2016 have ended in failure. **4**

VS Spam

depends on the level of compliance the detailed regulation spells out. It would be advisable to not record personally identifiable information about the user on the blockchain directly. This is particularly important given the upcoming data privacy regulations which empower a consumer to ask to be forgotten (deletion of all their personally identifiable data) by a service provider when they stop using a service. The consensus part of a blockchain is an underlying mechanism to ensure that all the nodes in the network consistently and securely record a given entry into the chain. It does not have any application specific connotations.”

Our final question to Kamat was the actual benefit to the end user. Kamat’s response was, “TRAI should be a party to the blockchain network that is recording the user consent, changes and communication logs. Since the marketing communications will be cross referenced with consent, any audits or complaint resolutions can be automated and cross checked

user about it. If that is made mandatory and also logged on the chain, it will empower the end user to revoke surreptitious consent. Overall the balance of power between the user and the telcos and marketers will be more even keeled offering more visibility and control to the end user.”

There are some questions regarding the implementation though. Shirsendu “Troy” Karmakar has outlined some concerns in the implementation of blockchain to tackle spam, in a response to TRAI’s consultation paper. The main problem point is that the blockchain implementation will be private and centralised, as against public and decentralised. This means that the authority can fudge the data in the blockchain, or the operators could collude among themselves to make changes. The security of the blockchain implementation comes into question, when it is a private, centralised blockchain. Additionally, there is no mining and no stake in the blockchain, giving the participants little